Research Paper Reading Checklist

Read a paper in about 30 minutes. Tick each box as you go.

Paper title: _____ Date: _____

1. Decide if it's worth reading (2 min)

- [ ] Read the title and abstract.
- [ ] Can I say what question the paper asks? If not, stop and pick another paper.

2. Read the figures first (8 min)

- [ ] Look at every figure and table, with its caption.
- [ ] Write one sentence per figure on what it shows.
- [ ] Check axes, units, error bars, and sample sizes.

3. Know what they set out to test (3 min)

- [ ] Read the last paragraph of the introduction.
- [ ] Note the hypothesis or aim in my own words.

4. Skim the methods for the design (5 min)

- [ ] Who or what was studied, and how many?
- [ ] What were the controls or comparison groups?
- [ ] What was the main measurement?

5. Match the results to my figure notes (5 min)

- [ ] Does the text agree with what I concluded from the figures?
- [ ] Note the effect size and p-value or confidence interval.

6. Read the discussion critically (5 min)

- [ ] List claims the data does not fully support.
- [ ] Note the limitations the authors admit, and any they missed.

Final test: summarize the paper in three sentences

Question: _____

Method: _____

Main result: _____

If you can fill in all three lines, you have read the paper well enough to discuss it.